



# The Andes

*The world's longest continental mountain range, comprising a series of impressive snow-capped peaks, volcanoes, and high plateaus*



The Andes extend for 4,500 miles (7,200 km) north to south along the western edge of South America, passing through Venezuela, Colombia, Ecuador, Peru, Bolivia, Argentina, and Chile. The range comprises several distinct subranges that formed in the last 50 million years. Some of these sit on either side of high-plateau regions, one of which, the Altiplano (see pp.96–97), is the world's second highest plateau after the Tibetan Plateau.

## Deserts and glaciers

The Andes are a formidable physical and biological barrier between the Pacific coast and the rest of South America, ranging in width from 60 miles (100 km) wide at the southern tip of the continent to 440 miles (700 km) in the central region. A variety of physical features can be found across the range, including one of the most arid places on Earth—the Atacama Desert (see pp.124–25)—

and some of the world's deepest canyons. In the Altiplano, there are vast salt flats and lakes. The southern sector of the Andes has been heavily glaciated in the past, and glaciers still extend down to sea level in southern Chile, where there is an extensive network of fjords (see p.117).

## Volcanoes and earthquakes

Interspersed within the Andes are about 180 active and numerous extinct volcanoes. They are the result of tectonic activity (see pp.94–95) that results in the production of magma under the Andes, where it rises to create substantial volcanic activity. This tectonic activity also generates earthquakes, including the most powerful ever recorded, which had its epicenter off the coast of Chile in 1960.

## ▽ MOUNTAIN PACK ANIMAL

Along with alpacas, vicuñas, and guanacos, llamas are one of four relatives of camels found in the Andes. While llamas and alpacas are domesticated, the others are wild.

